WASHINGTON COURTS

Washington Courts: Press Release Detail

Washington Supreme Court issues COVID-19 vaccination requirement for employees by November 1st; Strongly encourages judicial branch to join mandate

August 18, 2021

On Wednesday, August 18th the Washington Supreme Court issued an order requiring employees of the Supreme Court (including the offices of the Reporter of Decisions, the Supreme Court Clerk, the Supreme Court Commissioner, and the State Law Library) to be fully vaccinated as a condition of continued employment by November 1, 2021. Similar to Governor Jay Inslee's recent announcement for certain state workers, two narrow exemptions will be allowed as outlined in the order. This order extends to volunteers and independent contractors.

The Court also directed the Administrative Office of the Courts to adopt a similar policy and strongly encouraged all courts and offices within the judicial branch to adopt and implement similar vaccine requirements for employees, volunteers, and contractors. Additional offices in the judicial branch include the Washington State Bar Association, the Washington State Office of Civil Legal Aid and the Washington State Office of Public Defense.

Decisions for trial courts and the Court of Appeals throughout Washington will be made by presiding judges, who are authorized by court rule to supervise the judicial business of the district.

The Temple of Justice remains closed to the public, with curbside services offered by the State Law Library and the Supreme Court Clerk's Office accepting filings electronically and by mail. While all departments are operating, by order of the Chief Justice, only fully vaccinated employees are authorized to enter the building on the Capitol Campus, effective immediately.

Oral arguments for the Supreme Court's Fall term will continue to be conducted remotely, with all arguments broadcast via TVW, Washington's Public Affairs Network.

The full text of the Supreme Court's order can be found here.

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